

Episode 96: The Sea and Sky I Realised Through Solar Eclipse Broadcasting, and Once Upon a Time... (58) – *Coo: Far From Home*

During the total solar eclipse on the 22nd, Tokyo's weather was completely overcast. I couldn't even see the partial eclipse with the naked eye. Unfortunately I was working, so I was glued to NHK General's eclipse broadcast on TV the whole time. Of course, digital terrestrial with HD LCD TV combination. Perfectly recorded on Blu-ray (laughs).

The southern islands in the eclipse path that had been talked about early on apparently had bad weather, and commercial stations seemed to suffer complete defeats. NHK, however, achieved complete victory with solid dual broadcasts from the eclipse observation ship in the Pacific and Iwo Jima!

While I'd been an astronomy boy since childhood, I actually wasn't deeply interested in eclipses, and even for this eclipse, I didn't go out for observations, having a casual attitude of "TV is fine."

But watching NHK's broadcast, I was completely hooked. Ah, I should have gone to see the eclipse (tears). Especially the observation ship tour in the Pacific.

NHK's broadcast footage was incredible! Well, the eclipse images themselves were still whatever (burst), but what was amazing was the surrounding scenery and landscape just before, during, and after totality.

The "moon's shadow" approached from the western horizon, gradually enveloping the surroundings. The sky, sea, and floating clouds that had been shining beautifully and vividly gradually lost their colour, changing to grey with a hint of purple. In response, outside the shadow, near the horizon, the sky became tinged yellow to orange by the same principle as sunset, with clouds floating against that sky becoming silhouettes.

That footage was incredible.

Mystical or rather, the sheer scale of that scene was overwhelmingly massive. I watched TV with bated breath as the landscape changed moment by moment. I could only groan while watching TV. Since it was an eclipse broadcast, naturally they showed diamond rings, the pitch-black sun, corona, and prominences, but I was thinking "don't bother showing the sun during totality, keep showing the landscape!" (laughs).

Whether the observation ship or Iwo Jima, they were surrounded 360 degrees by ocean. I think that location made the footage even more spectacular.

Particularly the Iwo Jima broadcast had an NHK commentator with a microphone providing live commentary while immersed in the changing scenery, but he was so overwhelmed by the landscape that he was at a loss for words.

While I knew intellectually what it would be like inside the shadow during a total eclipse, ah, this is it. You really have to experience the real thing. Why didn't I apply? Well, applications closed a year in advance, so it would have been impossible anyway.

Total solar eclipses occur somewhere in the world almost every year. So with some (considerable) effort, it's not impossible to travel overseas to see eclipses. So in the not-too-distant future, I want to experience a total solar eclipse over the ocean. That's how deeply it moved me.

Now then.

Such southern sea landscapes. *Coo: Far From Home*. Of course, there was no eclipse in the story (laughs), but the beautiful scenery I saw in the broadcast was being painted by art director Yamamoto Nizo-san.

The *Coo: Far From Home* staff room was then located on the 3rd floor of the building facing the main entrance of Oizumi Studio, in what was called the "theatrical room."

Yamamoto-san had his desk in that room, steadily painting art boards and beautiful background paintings for the main production every day.

Having everyone including the director work in one place is the ideal setup. Having the director, animation director, and art director all together was a very reassuring environment. Well, that's how it should be originally, but it's hard to achieve. Now with digital dominance, art staff can work with just computers, but back then they painted normally with watercolours, needing paints, brushes, and numerous other supplies. Since they used water, they needed nearby water access too. So art staff mostly worked at their respective art studios except during meetings.

Both backgrounds and animation finishing gradually progressed, and cuts (in-betweens) for evening and night scenes started coming to colour direction. When a certain number of cuts accumulated in my hands, I'd decide special scene colours while watching the situation with art boards for those scenes.

I created and decided various colours in sequence - not just daytime, but several evening colours for different time progressions, early morning colours, etc. And finally came the first half's climax: "night" scenes.

(09.07.24)